drowned, with perhaps twins in her,
kicking at blank walls
even before birth.

He said:
the river has water enough
to be poetic
about only once a year
and then
it carries away
in the first half-hour
three village houses,
a couple of cows
named Gopi and Brinda
and one pregnant woman
expecting identical twins
with no moles on their bodies,
with different coloured diapers
to tell them apart.

Glossary

trickle(n) - to flow in a thin gentle stream
baring (v) - uncovering
ribs (n) - curved ridges
straw (n) - dry stalks
clogging (v) - blocking
lounging (v) - relaxing
precise(adj.) - exact
cobbled (adj.) - paved with stones
verse (n) - poetry
moles (n) - marks on the body

d) Having read the poem, answer the questions given below.

1.What does the opening line speak about?

2. What does the river look like in summer?

3.How is Madurai described in the poem?

4. What happens when the river is dry in summer?

5. What do the people talk about during the flood?

6. What else do the people talk about the flood?

7.What does the poet convey?

8.Can you identify two similes in the first stanza of the poem?

e) Following is the summary of the poem. Fill in the blanks with your understanding of the poem.

The poem is about a _____, which flows through the _____ city. Poets have written many poems on the _____. The poet presents two _____ pictures of the river in summer and during the _____. People remember how _____ village houses, a pregnant lady and a couple of _____ were washed away.

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